

Strength Routine

Five exercises, no equipment, three levels, and a four-week log · Module 3, Training 3

Why

Trained muscle takes up blood sugar with less insulin (Strasser & Pesta, *BioMed Research International*); resistance training improved lean mass and metabolic markers in PCOS (Kogure et al., *Medicine & Science in Sports & Exercise*); entering pregnancy strong supports posture, back and recovery (ACOG committee opinion on physical activity in pregnancy); ACSM recommends strength work for all major muscle groups at least twice a week.

Safety

Check with your doctor or a physiotherapist first if you have a back, knee, hip or pelvic condition, or are pregnant. Form over numbers. Breathe out on the effort; never hold your breath. Sharp pain = stop. Dull ache a day or two later = normal.

The routine: 3 rounds · 8–12 reps · rest 60 s · about 20 minutes · twice a week, a day apart

#	EXERCISE	SET-UP	MOVEMENT	WATCH FOR	BEGINNER VERSION
1	Squat	feet shoulder-width, toes slightly out, "chair behind you"	hips back, then knees bend; chest up, weight in heels; press heels to stand, squeeze glutes	knees track over toes, not inward; heels stay down	sit down onto a real chair and stand up
2	Glute bridge	on back, knees bent, feet flat hip-width, arms by sides	press heels, lift hips to a straight line shoulders-to-knees; squeeze 2 s; lower slowly	don't arch the low back to get higher	smaller lift, no hold
3	Plank	forearms and knees, elbows under shoulders	tuck toes and lift knees (or keep knees down); body one line; belly gently drawn in; breathe	hips level, not sagging or piked; 20 s = one set, build to 40 s	knee plank, 10–15 s

#	EXERCISE	SET-UP	MOVEMENT	WATCH FOR	BEGINNER VERSION
4	Bird dog	hands and knees, wrists under shoulders, knees under hips	extend right arm and left leg; hips square, back flat ("balance a cup of tea"); hold a breath; switch	no twisting; slow	arm only, then leg only
5	Wall push-up	arm's length from a wall, hands shoulder-height, slightly wider than shoulders	bend elbows, chest to wall, body one line; press back	elbows about 45° from the body	stand closer to the wall

Progression

LEVEL	WHEN	SQUAT	BRIDGE	PLANK	BIRD DOG	PUSH-UP
1 · Beginner	now	chair squat	standard	knees, 20 s	short hold	wall
2 · Intermediate	2–3 weeks, when 3 rounds feel comfortable	full squat	2-s pause at top	toes, 30 s	3-breath hold	kitchen counter
3 · Progressing	after another month	backpack with books	single-leg	40–60 s	slow, 5-breath hold	low table, then floor

Four-week progress log (30 XP: log each session)

WEEK	SESSION	DATE	LEVEL	SQUAT (REPS × ROUNDS)	BRIDGE	PLANK (S)	BIRD DOG	PUSH- UP	HOW IT FELT (1 WORD)
1	A								
1	B								
2	A								
2	B								
3	A								
3	B								
4	A								
4	B								

What got easier: _____ · What I'm proud of: _____

Share motivation (20 XP)

Post one sentence for the person who is nervous about their first plank.

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Educational content only, not medical advice. Always consult your doctor or a qualified health professional before changing supplements, diet, exercise or detox practices, especially while trying to conceive.